

art gallery with his son-in-law. Next to him is Art, the former head of General Motors. He's retired now, but he's trying to get a parts distributorship. Bob, there, is retired from Firestone, but he's helping his son-in-law open a restaurant."

The host seemed reluctant to "admit" that anyone was retired—until he got to me. He looked my way, paused, and then said, "Paul, there, he's really retired. He travels, plays the saxophone, goes to the beach for three months at a time, writes novels, goes to parties, and generally goofs off. I mean, he's retired retired."

The new arrival turned to me and raised his eyebrows. All retirees except me were over 60 years old. Yet, I was the only one "retired retired."

Why was the host embarrassed to introduce people as "retired"? I think it's because "retired" has come to mean "nonproductive." The club member was too polite to call anybody names. But consider what Americans call productive. Make napalm, grow tobacco, distill whiskey, or sell handguns and you're productive. Sign forms for the government, hype toothpaste, collect tolls on a bridge, or play pro ball and you're productive. Retire and you pass to nonproductive status. Whether you write, sing, play golf, travel, or meditate makes no difference. You're still retired. And that seems to define your role in life.

In Spanish, people who work form society's *sector activo*, or active sector. Retired people belong to the *sector pasivo*, or passive sector.

Pretty blunt. Also pretty wrong. Retired young people I know are proud to be retired. We view retirement as a move from one active sector of society to another. When we retire we feel we do more, not less. We believe that what we are or do defines our lives rather than what we earn or how we earn it. We think 1950s beatniks, 1960s hippies, 1970s dropouts, and 1980s drug addicts are losers. We're winners. We had successful, reasonably lengthy careers and made some dough. Now we're active, vibrant people who want to do other things.